

# THE PRICE OF ATTENTION

When a strait narrows and a price jumps, the task is not to stop caring about the bill. It is to refuse the comfort of caring about the bill alone.

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A trading screen has no smell. It has red and green candles, tiny arrows, a decimal point that appears to matter with the gravity of weather. On Wednesday, as the United States and Iran traded further strikes, oil rose to a six-week high and tanker movement through the Strait of Hormuz remained under threat. Brent crude pushed above \$93 a barrel. In offices far from the Gulf, that fact travelled as a clean, urgent number.

But the number is an echo, not the event. The United Nations, reporting this week on the continuing strikes, described civilians and critical infrastructure again under fire. There are people listening for explosions, deciding whether to leave, waiting for news from a relative. There are crews at sea whose route has become a question of risk. Before oil becomes a line item, it is tied to a geography in which ordinary life has become precarious.

The strait is only a narrow passage between Iran and Oman, but it carries a very large share of the world's seaborne energy. Its importance is usually expressed as a percentage of supply, a number so useful that it can quietly substitute for imagination. We say the shipping lane is constrained, the market is nervous, inflation may return. All true. Yet these phrases have a strange power: they turn a crisis of bodies, homes and choices into a crisis of arithmetic.

This is the human tension of the price board. We need abstractions. They let societies coordinate. A driver needs to know what fuel costs; a family needs to anticipate a heating bill; a central bank must assess inflation. The fault is not calculation. The fault arrives when calculation gives us permission to look away - when the elegant dashboard makes distant suffering feel like someone else's raw material.

*“A price can signal danger. It cannot tell us whose danger it is.”*

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The philosopher Iris Murdoch offered a demanding word for the alternative: attention. For her, moral life did not begin with grand declarations of virtue. It began with learning to see another person more justly, beyond the distortions of fear, vanity and convenience. Attention is not sentimentality. It does not claim that feeling bad is the same as helping. It is the discipline of allowing reality to correct the story we have made for ourselves.

That discipline matters whenever the world reaches us in compressed form. A chart is not a lie; it is a selection. A headline is not indifference; it is necessarily brief. The ethical question is what we do after the compression. Do we let the shorthand become the whole truth? Or do we make a small effort to restore the people, places and limits that shorthand has removed?

There is a practical difference. To say, "oil is up because of the Middle East," is to name a region as a market variable. To say that renewed attacks are putting civilians at risk and disrupting a passage relied on by many economies is slower, less tidy and more accurate. The second sentence does not solve a war. It does prevent our language from pretending that price is the primary injury.

Murdoch's lens also makes room for a crucial humility. We cannot follow every crisis to its full depth. Most of us have no control over diplomacy, air defenses, shipping insurance or the timing of strikes. Attention is not a command to become omniscient, or to perform anguish in public. It is a refusal to confuse our limited power with a license for limited concern.

The temptation to shrink the world into what affects us personally is understandable. If oil climbs, we see the future cost of a taxi, groceries, a holiday, a small business's delivery bill. These are real pressures. A moral imagination that dismisses them becomes decorative. But the reverse error is more common: treating our inconvenience as the story, and the violence that made the inconvenience possible as background noise.

So what does attention look like on an ordinary Thursday? It may begin with a noun. When a story enters conversation as "the oil thing," name what is happening without pretending to expertise: attacks are continuing; civilians are exposed; a shared route is under strain. The point is not to win an argument. It is to keep reality from being edited down to the part that reaches our wallet.

Then widen the question by one turn. If a higher price worries us, ask who faces the direct danger before the price arrives. If a company's delivery is delayed, ask what systems and workers carry the burden of rerouting. If we are reading markets, ask what the market cannot price: grief, fear, the long work of rebuilding trust. This is a modest habit, but habits determine the moral resolution at which we live.

Finally, let attention lead to proportionate action. Read reporting that treats civilians as more than scenery. Support reliable humanitarian relief when you can. Resist sharing claims that make an already dangerous situation harder to understand. In a workplace, avoid turning a conflict into a conversational commodity. None of this confers innocence. It simply makes our concern a little less captive to our own immediate interests.

The world will keep sending us events as alerts, prices and graphs. We will need those instruments; a society without them would be blind in another way. But an instrument is not an eye. The harder work is to let the number point beyond itself, toward the lives it cannot contain. When the next red candle flashes on a screen, what will we choose to notice before we ask what it costs us?

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